Moral Injury Among Parents Involved in the Child Protection System

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Introduction

This project examines **moral injury** in the experiences of parents involved in the child protection system. **Moral injury is the lasting psychological, spiritual/existential and social harm caused by one's own or others' actions in high stakes situations that transgress deeply held moral beliefs and expectations.**

Moral injury may co-occur with, but it is distinct from experiences of trauma. Although moral injury has been examined primarily with war veterans (see Litz et al., 2009; Shay, 1994), individuals in other high stakes contexts such as child protection also may experience violations of fundamental moral principles by the self and/or someone in authority (Haight et al., 2016). Addressing any moral injury experienced by parents may improve outcomes for families involved in the child protective system. Individuals experiencing moral injury display psychological distress, and may resist or be disengaged from social/psychological services. Furthermore, they might not benefit from extant evidence-based interventions which fail to address the experience of moral injury. This is the first study to examine the applicability and characteristics of moral injury to parents in the high stakes context of the child protection system.

Research Questions

1. Do some parents experience moral injury in relation to their experiences with CPS?
2. If so, what do parents and professionals identify as morally injurious events for parents?
3. If so, how do parents and professionals describe the psychosocial effects of morally injurious events on parents?

Methods

Design

Convergent mixed methods design (Creswell, 2013) for the purpose of complementarity (Greene, 2007)

Sample

Parents

- Purposive sample recruited primarily through a legal clinic for indigent parents accused of child maltreatment
- 10 parents, 1 father and 9 mothers
- 5 White, 5 African American
- 4 open cases, one termination of parental rights (TPR) under appeal, and 5 closed cases (4 reunified, 1 TPR)

Professionals

- Convenience sample recruited through the legal clinic, LinkedIn, and snowball sampling
- 10 certified student attorneys who represent parents, 15 social workers, 5 county attorneys, 5 guardian ad litems
- 66% White, 13% Black, 8% Latino, 5% Asian, 5% Multi-Ethnic and 3% Native American.
- 82% female and 18% male.
- Average of 8.5 years of experience in CPS.

Instruments

- **Morally Injurious Events Scale (MIES) (Nash et al., 2013).** 9; Likert Scale: Strongly Agree (6) to Strongly Disagree (1)
- **Semi structured interview** probed MIES items endorsed as "strongly agree" or "moderately agree," e.g., "I see that you "strongly agree" that you are troubled by having witnessed others' immoral acts. Tell me about that…What happened…How did you feel?…"

Procedures:

- Sessions conducted in private locations of participant's choosing such as home or library.
- 60-90 minute individual, audiotaped semi-structured interviews

Data Analysis:

- Descriptive statistics calculated for each of the 3 factors of the MIES (Nash et al., 2013).
- Emic codes were induced through repeated readings of each transcribed interview.
- All interviews were independently coded by two researchers and disagreements were resolved through discussion.

Results

1. **Do some parents experience moral injury in relation to their experiences with CPS?**

- 8 of 10 parents endorsed that they saw things that were morally wrong and were troubled by having witnessed others' immoral acts.

2. **If so, what do parents and professionals identify as morally injurious events for parents?**

- Troubling events involved problematic services and professionals and the adversarial nature of the CPS system.

3. **If so, what do parents and professionals identify as morally injurious events for parents?**

- Parent responses included emotional distress, existential issues and psychosomatic reactions.

Table 1
Integrated Description of Parent, Family, MIES Scores and Responses to Qualitative Interview

Parent	Grace	Dana	Ella	Jen	Fiona	Hazel	Ingrid	Ann	Beth	Carl
Race	White	Black	White	White	Black	White	Black	Black	Black	White
Age	Midlife	Young	Young	Midlife	Young	Midlife	Young	Midlife	Midlife	Midlife
Income	15-30 /yr	15-30 /yr	15-30 /yr	15-30 /yr	<15/yr	>65/yr	15-30/yr	<15/yr	45-60 /yr	15-30 /yr
Education	12	12	12	16	11	16	GED	GED	14	12
Relationship Status	Separated	Single	Partner	Divorced	Single	Married	Single	Married	Single	Separated
# of children	4	3	3	3	4	3	1	4	3	8
CPS Issue	Palpably Unfit	Abuse	Abuse / Drugs	Neglect	Med neglect	Sibling Abuse	Neglect	Abuse	Abuse	Abuse / Neglect
Case Status	Closed	Closed	Open	Closed	Open	Open	Appeal	Closed	Open	Closed
Case Outcome	TPR	Reunified	N/A	Reunified	N/A	N/A	TPR	Reunified	N/A	Reunified
MIES (1 low, 6 high)										
Transgress-other / Event	6	6	6	6	4	6	4	5	5	2
Transgress-other /Troubled	6	5	5	6	4	6	4	5	3	2
Betrayed	6	5	2.5	6	5	3	3.5	3.5	2.5	2
Transgress- self / Event	4.5	5.5	6	3.5	5	1	2.5	2	2.5	1
Transgress-self /Troubled	4.5	5	6	2.5	4	1	3	1	1.5	1
MEAN	5.4	5.3	5.1	4.8	4.4	3.4	3.4	3.3	2.9	1.6
Morally injurious events										
Professionals Problematic	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Services Problematic	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
System Adversarial	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y		
Parents Problematic	Y	Y	Y	N	Y	N	Y	Y		
Children Harmed	N	Y	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	N		Y
Bad laws/policies	Y	Y	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y		
System Biased	N	N	N	Y	Y	N	N	N	Y	
Responses										
Emotional Distress	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Existential Issues	N	Y	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	N		
Domino Effect	Y	Y	N	N	Y	N	Y	Y		
Psychosomatic	Y	Y	N	N	N	Y	N	Y		
Social /Emotional Growth	Y	Y	Y	N	N	N	Y	N		

Conclusions

- Moral injury appears to be present in some parents involved with CPS.
- These parents' MIES scores are similar to those obtained from military veterans.
- Parents described responses to experiences associated with moral injury that echoed those found in military veterans such as feelings of anger/outrage, powerlessness, guilt and shame/humiliation.
- Events that parents find morally injurious are associated with people and systems that are entrusted with helping that instead cause harm.
- Parents experiencing moral injury are diverse with respect to ethnicity, and case status and outcomes.

Limitations

- Small sample both for the quantitative component which was not randomly selected, and the qualitative component where saturation of themes was not reached.
- Modified an instrument designed for military context which may affect psychometric properties.

Implications

- Instruments with known psychometric properties for use in CPS contexts need to be researched.
- Prevalence studies are needed with parents involved with CPS.
- Preventing or addressing parents' moral injury may improve outcomes for families involved with CPS.

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